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Congress 408: Seminar - Senate Office Structure

Effortpost

Introduction

This post is a little different than the other ones, more of a special topic explanation instead of something more overarching.

If you've spent any amount of time keeping up with this series then you know I haven't been taking these posts too seriously. I'd benefit from an editor, I'd benefit from rereading the paragraphs I write. I don't consistently capitalize words that should or shouldn't be Capitalized, hyphenation is done by ear instead of by adhering to a style-guide, and sometimes I'll write a sentence without dropping in a very important comma so the entire thing becomes illegible and you're stuck wondering "does this guy really know what he's talking about?"

No. I don't. More fairly you could say I *barely* do but, for brevity, no. This entire series has been predicated on being written by someone who works in the Senate, not somebody who understands it. How can you work here and not understand the place? Well, and I've said this in every single post about the Senate, the Senate doesn't make any sense. Seriously, some Senators hire a full time employee to be their "special assistant" or their "procedural chief" or literally any other B.S. title, purely because they need someone on their staff who knows Senate procedure by heart.

That's a bit of a tangent, anyway, I don't take these posts too seriously. Now please recall all those other posts I didn't take seriously, and use that memory to contextualize this next sentence.

This will be the least polished post of them all. Here are the links to the other one in case you want to read something more polished:

[Part 4](#) [Part 3](#) [Part 2](#) [Part 1](#) [Part 0](#)

You're a Senator, now what?

Picture this: The year is 2024. After a bitter divorce and a disastrous Yeezy launch, the only human being left in Wyoming is Kanye West. After bravely venturing into the State, [u/Peacock-Shah](#) emerges the Junior Senator of the most insanely disproportionately represented part of the country.

Now what? Well, mostly, I have no idea. The House has a really well documented new-Member orientation process because they have to do it for like 50 people every two years. Meanwhile, 10 is huge turnover on this side of the Capitol, so every two years you have maybe four or five guys learning the basics of the process straight from the Secretary. Beside that, the Senate has a long history of not having new Member services to promote inter-office alliances. Barry Goldwater's quote at the top of the [Senate's page on orientations](#) explains this dynamic pretty well.

Here are some things I do know: Senators need a staff and a place to put them, and the negotiations for both of these things begin *and* end before January 3rd when the new Congress is inaugurated.

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by underground tunnels. Within these tunnels you have walking paths and rails for trains. In order from North to South the offices go: Hart, Dirksen, Russell, Capitol-S. The "S" stands for Senate, not South, the House is on the South side and all of the doors over there say "H."

The further you get from the Capitol Building, the newer the office you're working in. Russell is known for its beautiful, stately, small, elegant offices that immediately instill a level of importance to the work being done within them. Hart is known for its incredible spaciousness (Senate offices here are two stories tall with stairs within them), its fantastic modularity, its big windows, and its modern fixtures. Dirksen is known for its stupid green hallways.

Senators negotiate with each other and with the Secretary of the Senate on where their office is going to be. Do you want something spacious and modern? Do you want something grand and official? Will you spend most of your time in your hideaway so you don't care what the hell the office looks like? It's up to you and whoever the hell you can trade with.

Hideaways are fun because they don't exist for Representatives in the House (I like this fact because it's another reason for me to feel smug). Aside from getting an office in one of the Senate Office Buildings (a personal one at that, usually with its own entrance and amenities and meeting area) every Senator has a room on the Senate side of the Capitol itself in case they need to do some business but they don't want to be more than an elevator ride away from the Senate Floor. They're unmarked, so usually the only way to know "hey that's (Senator)'s hideaway" is by having worked for them.

Hideaways can be the size of a walk-in closet with nothing more than a phone and a desk in them for the low rank Senators in the seniority hierarchy, or they can be these gorgeous big personal offices with bookshelves and seating areas that could end up on HGTV if their tenant wanted them to be. Here are [Franken and Klobuchar's hideaways](#) circa 2010, Franken looks like he got a good deal on a bigger spot than usual by agreeing to take a room on the terrace level (that's between basement 1 and 2 for you Government architecture fans). [Here's a slideshow of pictures from Mikulski's hideaway](#) circa 2014, completely on the other side of the spectrum.

Staff

Most Senators have long histories in politics. This is a good and a bad thing. For this conversation, this history that a person drags with them into office is great. Being able to recall people whom you've hired in the past speeds up the process of filling an office considerably. In the moments right after your race is called, having an LD or a District Director on speed dial means having an entire office on speed dial.

These connections have limitations. You, an incumbent member, might have worked in the House for your entire career and so nobody you know has Senate experience. Or maybe, you, an incumbent member, were formerly the Governor of your State, so nobody you know has experience with the Federal Government. That's fine, your people know people who might know people, your Senior Senator in the State you represent might have a good list of contacts to share, and you can always ask your party for help.

As a Senator, you'll get a number from the Secretary of the Senate's office that's the cap on how much you can spend on Staff. In the House there's a hard cap of 8 permanent staff per Representative (in regard to their personal office, not the office they assume in leadership or through committee work). That's the reason Pelosi has her Speaker's office *and* her CA-12 office, she can only have 8 people in the latter. The hard cap doesn't exist in the Senate, if you can pay for 10 people then you have 10 people, if you can pay for 70 people then

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Offices are usually *built* top down, but I'll explain them bottom up. Let's start with the ladder I'm on:

At the lowest level in an office you have **Interns**, no less than 4 but there technically isn't a maximum. I've heard of offices with as many as 15. Sometime in 2018 the Ethics Committee greenlit an initiative to pay all interns working for any Senator's personal office. The role of interns is entirely dependent on their Senator, they might be answering phones, they might be writing constituent letters, but most of the time they're just there for everyone to dump work on them.

Interns report to an intern coordinator, who themselves is most often one of the office's **Staff Assistants**. There's usually 2 of these guys, there could be 1, I don't know if there's an office with more than 2. Staff Assistants have a variety of jobs that make sure things run smoothly, they greet office visitors, they arrange tours of the Capitol, they keep track of staff meetings and everybody's calendar to make sure there's a place for meetings to take place, they accept mail, they make sure dear colleague letters are signed and documented, they process Flag requests (fun thing to do if you don't know about it), and in rare occasions they jump on the phones when some atrocity has happened and the lines are blowing up (which happened so fucking much when Trump was President).

The people who spend the most amount of time corresponding with constituents, though, are the **Legislative Correspondents**. If the interns aren't allowed to write letters its because it's these guys' jobs to write them, if the interns can't answer phones its because the Senator wants professionals doing it (and that means these guys), and so on and so forth. As an LC, you get a portfolio, a collection of issues that you're responsible for handling. You take meetings about those issues, you go to hearings and briefings about those issues, you write letters about those issues, you might even get to brief the Senator and write laws about those issues. Issues are broad but they make sense when you list them all out and give them to a person. My portfolio is Armed Services, Foreign Relations, Veteran's Affairs, and recently I've picked up Intelligence and Trade (but those might be temporary, I don't know yet). It's very common for an LC in any office who's set to cover one of those issues to also be handling the other four. There's a harmony to them, my job is to look at things happening mostly outside of the US, these are issues that impact that area. There are tons of pairings like this: Banking goes with Finance goes with Small Businesses, Criminal Justice goes with Judiciary goes with Judicial Nominations, CST goes with Energy goes with Natural Resources goes with Environment/Public Works goes with Indian Affairs. There's overlap.

The boss of every LC is an LA, a **Legislative Assistant** or maybe sometimes if their job is very special a **Legislative Aide**. These are senior-level staff who have a certain level of expertise in the portfolio they cover, which can either be more specific or more broad than that of their LCs. An LC working on Foreign Relations issues might spend their day doing background work on an upcoming hearing, taking meetings with constituents who care about the issue at hand, going back and forth with CRS and the Parliamentarian's office about legal paths to make something particular happen, preparing briefings for their Senator, and maybe, *maybe* they put some language somewhere. An LA writes the fucking law. I don't care what clip or soundbite you find of a politician saying "I wrote this bill, I wrote this law, I wrote this clause," no. I can count on one hand the number of Senators currently serving who've written a law, and still have fingers left over to pick my nose. Anyway, LAs are very experienced people, maybe ex-Executive employees, maybe long-time junior level staff on the Hill, ex lobbyists, they know their issues very well. LAs accompany the Senator to high-value Committee meetings, LAs brief the Senator on developments they're familiar with, LAs talk to LAs with their portfolio in different offices to make sure project that their Senator cares about actually fucking happen, and in their free time they write the fucking law. LAs are cool.

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LD job is to make sure that laws are written, laws are proposed, and our changes are made to other people's laws. They're the green light, the yellow light, the red light, and the cop lights pulling you over. If the Senator says "listen, I'm really trying to push (this thing) this week," the LD is doing the pushing, moving people to where they're most valuable to make it happen. Since this job is very coordinative, the LD and the Senator spend a significant amount of time together, their day-to-day work lines up better than anyone else's. Usually, the LD is allowed to sign documents on behalf of the Senator, so part of their job is signing letters too.

The other person who can sign letters on the Senator's behalf, other than the Senator him or herself, is the only person who outranks the LD: the **Chief of Staff**. CoS is the boss when the boss isn't around and a little bit even when the boss is around. They're in charge of hiring, firing, managing, operating, and in any other synonym: running the office. While the Legislative Director spends their days working on getting particular words in particular bills to impact particular people because the Senator particularly said to work on that particular thing, the Chief spends his or her time thinking more strategically, more holistically, more completely about achieving office goals. The LD's job is to make sure a law that impacts this population of people passes, the Chief's job is to make sure the media team runs a story about how the law is important, the outreach team prepares impacted people in the State for the law's passing, and the exec team actually has a fucking printed copy of the bill going to the Cloak room while the Senator is on the floor getting ready for it to be read twice and forwarded to the relevant Committee. The Senator says "I want to work on nuclear threat reduction" for example, and the LD says "ok, I know Blumenthal's running a bill on that, let's add our stuff in and join as an original cosponsor," but the Chief says "That's the third time this Congress you've talked about that, CSIS is finishing their fellowship selection in a week, let's pick someone up with a security background."

You might find yourself employed to do a different job on a Senator's staff. Since the most junior Senators can be on triple the number of Committees as your average Representative in the House, a Senator will often times have a **Body Man**, an **Executive Assistant**, a **Deputy Scheduler**, and a **Scheduler**. The roles which these jobs handle can be distributed very differently from office to office, but in aggregate the Executive team (as they're usually called) is in charge of making sure every second of the Senator's day is planned out, that plan is carried out, and all necessary materials relevant to the plan are with the Senator at all times. Over the course of one day these guys could be in charge of making sure the poor bastard makes it to every Committee meeting, every floor vote, every key Constituent meeting, every phonecall from their main office, every phonecall from their hideaway, and on a plane to get back to their State, while also factoring in time for meals, bathroom breaks, and walking between any two things I've mentioned thus far required for living long enough to actually run the country they stand in. Tired yet? So are they. Highest senior-level turnover on the Hill is on this team.

Usually most media people start as **Media Interns** tasked with transcribing videos of your Senator for closed captioning or white balancing photos. From there, depending on the office you might find yourself promoted to the **Media Assistant** who actually handles the camera and writes early press releases for the Senator's website. After that you have some combination of **Communications Associate** and **Communications Director** who handle their own portfolio of media companies who might want to get the Senator on-record. Usually the split is between Local and National media, one of these two talks to Fox5, the other talks to CNN. **Digital Directors** are an increasingly common feature in Senate offices, handling all the official social media accounts that are attached to the Senator's website. If the Senator has a social media account that isn't linked to on their website, that account is most likely part of their campaign operation and they can't use public funds to promote or operate it so you'll never have someone on the Hill managing it unless it's the Senator themself.

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effectiveness, are both pretty critical tasks that require a pretty unique skill set.

Most of the time these outreach guys have the most conversations with district staff out of anyone in that Senator's office on the Hill. Do you know about these guys? **District staff?** I talk about them every now and again, but every Member of Congress is supposed to have at least one office in the constituency they represent, filled with social workers, who get a salary made up of taxpayer funds, tasked with making people's interactions with Government easier. Now in the most narrow definition of their jobs, these guys only have the authority to help you with your interactions with the *Federal* Government (which is a pretty small percentage of a regular American's interactions with Government overall, it's way more likely you have a problem with your State or Municipality). That being said, most of the time Senators ask their district staff to help people with State-level or Municipal-level problems. I can't really go into the job so much because I've spent a combined 20 hours over two years interacting with the district teams I work with, but I'll say this: a lot of people don't know that there are people waiting for you to call if you have a problem with USCIS, or with the IRS, or with HUD, or with the VA, or with literally any other Federal agency that you run into. I'm not saying "a lot of people don't know," to disparage anyone if they weren't aware these offices existed, as a matter of fact some Members of Congress had no idea these things existed *months* into their first terms. One in particular in the 116th comes to mind, first one to guess who it is gets gold.

There are a ton of other jobs that fall into special categories, IT Coordinator, Human Resources Officer, Mail Chief, Speechwriter, Legislative Fellow, Special Advisor on [Topic], and a laundry list of others, but their jobs are easy enough to infer from the job title and they aren't present in every office.

Resources

These jobs are demanding, they require a lot of work, and they also require a lot of knowledge sometimes. If you need help with either the work or the knowledge component of your job, there are resources provided by your chamber's officers to help.

Imagine you're sending your Senator down on the floor to make some big point about ecological problems in the Mozambique Channel that have strategic implications. You want one of those big posters. Head on down to *Printing and Direct Mail* and they can make you some.

Imagine you're writing language set to increase funding for highway projects that link interstate counties that fall in the same metropolitan area. It'd be a good idea for you to reach out to the *Congressional Research Service* and ask if they have a list of exactly how many of those counties exist in this country.

Imagine your Senator has been trying to push this DoJ authorization and the media team is looking for the recording of "Little Ralphie" Scopo extorting that contractor in the 80s that led to the Mafia Commission Trial. Sounds like a wonderful job for one of the *Librarians of Congress*.

My point here is that there's a ton of different people you can reach out to for different reasons.

Conclusion

Usually I say something witty here about what I just wrote and how it ties into the next post but I **need** to mention this in one of my posts and I think it goes here, so here goes.

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Schwimmer. It's somebody from the Sergeant at Arms' office going over safe workplace practices, explaining boundaries between appropriateness and inappropriateness, and it cuts to an example and Ross from Friends is acting out what you shouldn't do. There's also clips from the Office in there. I had to get this off my chest, it was such a crazy thing to me that they licensed this shit.

Anyway, next time we'll be talking about more advanced topics.

↑ 64 ↓ 4

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GlazedFrosting • 5y ago

I love this series! It's cool to learn about the inside of this really powerful institution. Your writing style is very engaging, too.



FireDistinguishers **OP** • 5y ago

Awe thanks man, I try to keep things engaging so it doesn't feel like you're reading a glossary



AutoModerator **MOD** • 5y ago

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TrekkiMonstr • 2y ago

The page on orientations is now a 404, so [here's an archived version](#). The relevant quote, I assume:

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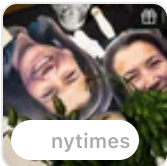
the phone rang and the voice at the other end said, "This is Mark Rice. I wondered then who that could be. He immediately told me that he was Secretary of the Senate and his interest that morning was in helping me to get started. He came to me like a life ring comes to a drowning man.

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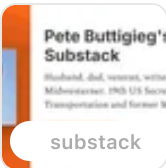
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As described in the Union, A nation which can't even resist who gets to be a citizen isn't a nation.
To amend the Constitution, This is possible, because once a judge decides to not enforce the Constitution at all, the Supreme and Federal did today, the actual text is meaningless. But this is what most GDP politicians provide voters because they are cowards.



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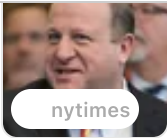
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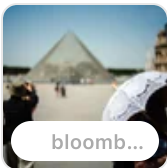
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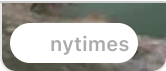


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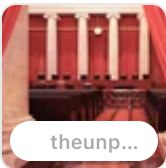
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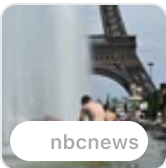
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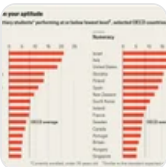
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